McCone delivered the disturbing news to the president on August 22. It came as an unpleasant surprise. In fact, a few hours before meeting with McCone, Kennedy, speaking at a press conference, had denied the presence of Soviet troops in Cuba. “Troops? We do not have information, but an increased number of technicians,” the president told a reporter. Now McCone suggested that there were not only troops on the island but perhaps missiles as well. The next day McCone told Kennedy that for the time being he could not distinguish surface-to-air missiles from surface-to-surface ones that would endanger US territory. Disturbed, Kennedy showered McCone with questions: could the missiles be taken out by an airstrike, ground invasion, or, alternatively, by sabotage or local insurgency?[17]

McCone had no answers to all the president’s questions, but he had a ready solution to the Cuban problem as a whole. The memo he submitted to Kennedy envisioned a three-step operation starting with an international public campaign against the Cuban regime, proceeding to the intensification of sabotage and covert operations on the island, and culminating in the “instantaneous commitment of sufficient armed forces to occupy the country, destroy the regime, free the people, and establish in Cuba a peaceful country which will be a member of the community of American states.” He hoped that successful implementation of the first two steps might make the third unnecessary but did not count on it. McCone confided to Robert Kennedy that he considered the developments in Cuba “our most serious problem.”

But President Kennedy and his advisers were not convinced. “Many in the room,” reads the CIA summary of the conversation, “related action in Cuba to Soviet actions in Turkey, Greece, Berlin, Far East and elsewhere.” McCone had a suggestion on how to solve the Turkish problem, arguing that the Jupiter medium-range missiles with nuclear warheads in Turkey and Italy presented no strategic advantage. McNamara agreed that they were of no use and undertook to investigate their removal. But there was no solution in sight for the Berlin problem. “President,” reads the protocol of the meeting, “raised question of what we should do in Cuba if Soviets precipitated a Berlin crisis. This is the alternative to the proposition of what Soviets would do in Berlin if we moved in Cuba.”[18]